

37 WEEKS At this point you are probably as big as you are going to get.



Baby watch

📏 19% in (49.8 cm) 📊 6 lb 10 oz (3.1 kg)

Now at full term, space is at a premium for your baby, and she may draw her legs and arms into her body in the classic fetal pose. The skull bones aren't fused, which allows the bony plates to overlap and elongate to help your baby squeeze through the birth canal.

Mom matters

Your movement may slow since your size makes it difficult to move quickly and maintain balance. Your breasts are ready to feed your baby at birth. The milk ducts have branched off, creating a transportation system to deliver milk to your baby.



This week...

» You will have a prenatal appointment this week. Your blood pressure and the baby's growth and position will be checked. Your doctor will talk to you about your options if you pass your due date, and will discuss the hospital's policy on inducing labor.

» Make a few home-cooked dishes to pop in the freezer for after the birth.

» Pack your hospital bag or make preparations for a home birth.

38 WEEKS Double-check your birth plan; it's not too late to make changes.



Baby watch

📏 20 in (50.7 cm) 📊 7 lb 3 oz (3.3 kg)

The gray matter of the brain, the cortex, develops in layers of cells. As each layer is complete, more connections are made between cells, which help to fine-tune your baby's movements. Thanks to antibodies from your blood, your baby has some protection from infection, and after birth she can continue to receive antibodies from your breast milk.

Mom matters

You may feel very fatigued in these final stages since you carry all the extra weight of the fetus, uterus, and extra fluid. Your heart is working at full capacity. Taking some time to lie down increases the blood flow to your baby, and helps you rest and recuperate.



This week...

» You may have a late burst of energy now and an urge to clean and scrub. If the "nesting" urge hits you, by all means go with it, but be careful not to overdo it.

» Practice breathing and relaxation techniques to help reduce anxiety.

39 WEEKS Make sure you are clear on how to recognize the signs of labor.



Baby watch

📏 20% in (51.2 cm) 📊 7 lb 11 oz (3.5 kg)

With her arrival imminent, your baby is well-prepared for life on the outside. Eyebrows, eyelashes, and nails are all in place, and her organs and body systems are sufficiently developed, though many of these will continue to develop after the birth.

Mom matters

It's best to take it easy now and conserve your energy for labor. Combine rests with periods of gentle activity. You are likely to feel a mounting pressure in your pubic region and your baby may be partially or fully engaged in your pelvis, although in second and subsequent pregnancies, this often happens later on.



This week...

» You will have a prenatal appointment this week where your doctor can check if the head is engaged and assess your baby's well-being.

» Relieve backaches with warm baths and a soothing massage.

40 WEEKS Very soon you will be holding your new baby in your arms.



Baby watch

📏 20% in (51.2 cm) 📊 7 lb 11 oz (3.5 kg)

At 40 weeks your baby has little space to move around. You're likely to feel her limbs protruding or her hiccupping. If she is born after 40 weeks she will have some vernix on her skin and may have less amniotic fluid surrounding her.

Mom matters

Approximately 45 percent of women haven't given birth at 40 weeks. However, the majority deliver during the next week and only 15 percent go above 41 weeks. You might be offered a "sweep" to induce labor. This encourages the release of hormones that help to start contractions.



This week...

» Keep your birth plan with you at all times. Your packed hospital bag should also be on hand.

» Make sure you have fuel in your car, coins for parking, and a fully charged phone and camera in your bag.

» Make sure the birthing center has your birth plan if that's where you will be giving birth.